west from the tenth to twelfth centuries, India was part of Fatimid and Mamluk trading networks centred in Egypt, and from there to Tunis and beyond. [45] Commercial and cultural contacts—including religion and writing systems—extended east as far as the Philippines. [46] To the north, between the sixteenth and eighteenth centuries, Indian traders and moneylenders plied their trade between Persia and Astrakhan in Russia. [47]

Yet the medieval and early modern period also saw a certain inwardness on the part of Indian rulers and the Mughals in particular. Indeed, a common view is that the Mughals had no real interest in overseas matters. For example, an anecdote recounted by the English ambassador to the Mughal Court, Thomas Roe, suggests that Emperor Jehangir was uninterested in European maps that were presented to him. This may be an overly simplistic conclusion, as Mughal courtiers would often request European maps and incorporate some of that knowledge into their own cartography. [48] At the same time, it is true that despite sometimes considering Sri Lanka, Aceh, and Malacca as parts of 'Hindustan', the Mughals did not develop an ocean-faring navy in an attempt to politically subjugate these regions. [49] For this reason, the Mughals' means of retaliation to piracy by the Dutch and English was to restrict their access to trade on land rather than fight back at sea, an approach that initially proved effective.

But a further puzzle is that despite steady trade and the import of mercenaries, the Mughal Empire made little attempt at claiming primacy within the Islamicate world. This was despite their being by far the largest polity and economy in this system, dwarfing even the Ottoman Caliphate and Safavids in Persia. Rivalries between these three 'gunpowder empires' certainly did exist. Akbar attempted to highlight his Empire's relative wealth by, for example, subsidizing the Hajj pilgrimage for his subjects, sending gift-laden delegations and making donations to Mecca and Medina. While giving themselves universal titles (Jahangir and Shah Jahan mean 'World Conqueror' and 'Lord of the World' respectively), the Mughals referred to the Ottomans only as Sultans rather than Caliphs. There were other forms of more direct competition, including between the Mughals and Safavids over control of Kandahar. The Mughals remained concerned about